

PROPOSED ON-GROUND IMPLEMENTATION SCHEME

for the Promotion and Implementation of the

Forest Rights Act (FRA) & Community Forest Rights (CFR)

*Community Forest Rights Awareness, Facilitation
and Digital Governance Initiative*

Powered by the VanMitra Digital Platform

A coordinated model involving the Forest Department, District-level authorities, NGOs, Gram Sabha institutions, Forest Rights Committees (FRC) / Community Forest Resource Management Committees (CFRMC), and technology support through the VanMitra application.

Prepared for Pilot Implementation and Stakeholder Review

August 31, 2026

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Executive Summary

This report presents a proposed on-ground implementation scheme for promoting awareness and strengthening the effective implementation of the **Forest Rights Act (FRA)**, with special emphasis on **Community Forest Rights (CFR)**, among eligible tribal and forest-dwelling communities.

The scheme is designed as a **community-centred facilitation and digital support ecosystem** – not as a replacement for the statutory FRA process. It integrates the Forest Department, District-level authorities, NGOs, Gram Sabha institutions, Forest Rights Committees (FRC), Community Forest Resource Management Committees (CFRMC), and the **VanMitra digital platform** to help communities understand their rights, prepare claims, track application progress, document Gram Sabha decisions, map recognised CFR areas, and build sustainable livelihoods around community-managed forests.

Long-Term Vision

Awareness → Rights → Recognition → Mapping → Governance → Sustainable Livelihood

The report is organised into twelve components – from village-level awareness generation through to sustainable livelihood development – followed by a description of stakeholder roles and a recommended small-scale pilot implementation plan.

1 FRA and CFR Awareness & Community Mobilisation Programme

The first stage of the proposed scheme focuses on creating awareness regarding the Forest Rights Act and Community Forest Rights among eligible tribal and forest-dwelling communities. A coordinated awareness programme is proposed at the village and cluster level, involving:

- Representatives or designated officers from the Forest Department / DFO office, wherever institutionally appropriate;
- Partner NGOs and community-based organisations;
- Gram Sabha representatives;
- FRC/CFRMC members;
- Local community volunteers; and
- The VanMitra implementation team.

1.1 Focus Areas of the Awareness Programme

- | | |
|--|---|
| • Purpose and benefits of the FRA | (FRC) |
| • Individual Forest Rights and Community Forest Rights | • Statutory stages in the claim process |
| • Eligibility and applicable rights of the community | • Importance of proper documentation and evidence |
| • Role of the Gram Sabha | • Process of recognition of CFR |
| • Role of the Forest Rights Committee | • Responsibilities of the community after CFR recognition |

1.2 Proposed On-Ground Activities

- Village-level awareness camps
- Gram Sabha awareness sessions
- Small group discussions
- Demonstrations of the VanMitra application
- Local-language information sessions
- Distribution of simplified FRA/CFR process guides
- Identification of potentially eligible households and communities

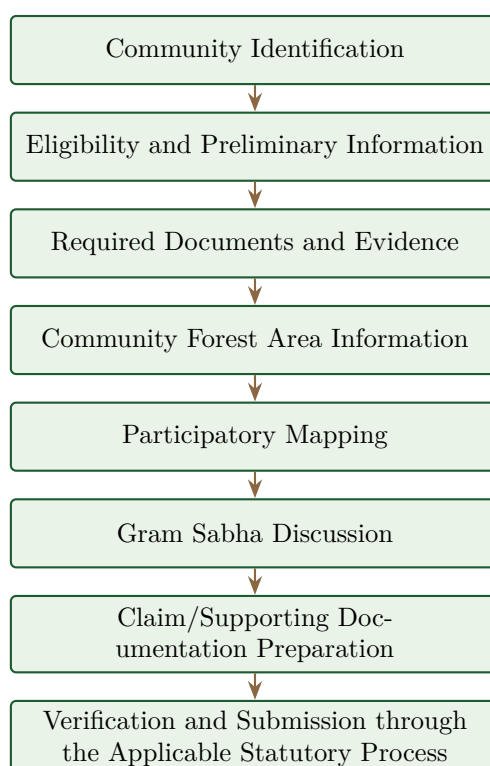
Objective

To ensure that the community is aware of its rights **before** beginning the documentation and claim process.

2 Community-Level Facilitation for CFR Claim Preparation

After the awareness stage, eligible villages and communities are supported in initiating and preparing their Community Forest Rights claims. VanMitra acts as a **digital facilitation platform**, helping the community and authorised facilitators organise the information required for the applicable CFR claim and supporting documentation, including the Joint Statement/Patra documentation and prescribed forms applicable to the pilot jurisdiction.

2.1 Claim Preparation Workflow



Important Principle

The app does **not** independently determine legal eligibility or approve a claim. It helps the community, NGO facilitators and authorised institutions organise and maintain the required information and documentation.

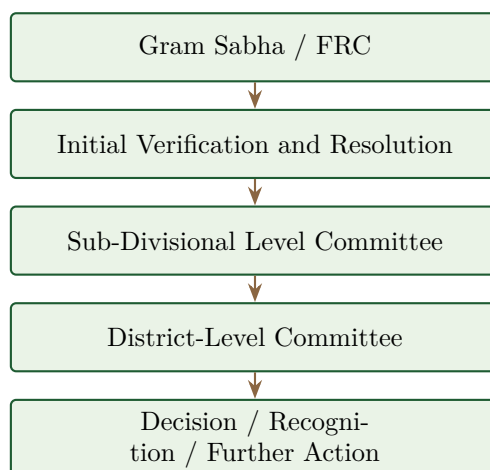
2.2 Key Features

- Digital checklist of required information and documents
- Community-wise claim records
- Evidence and document management
- Uploading of supporting documents
- Geo-tagged field observations
- Participatory land and forest-area information
- Digital preparation of supporting records
- Claim readiness checklist
- Exportable documentation for review by appropriate authorities

3 Step-by-Step Claim Procedure and Status Tracking

A major proposed feature of the system is a **transparent step-by-step tracking mechanism**. After a claim enters the statutory process, VanMitra provides a simplified view of its progress through the relevant institutional stages.

3.1 Claim Progress Workflow



3.2 Information Displayed for Every Claim

- Current stage
- Date of submission
- Documents submitted
- Verification status
- Pending requirements
- Action required from the community
- Status updates from the authorised process
- Final decision or recognition status

Purpose

To improve transparency and help communities understand where their claim currently stands and what action is required next. The application functions as a **community-facing tracking and documentation system**, while official legal decisions remain with the competent statutory authorities.

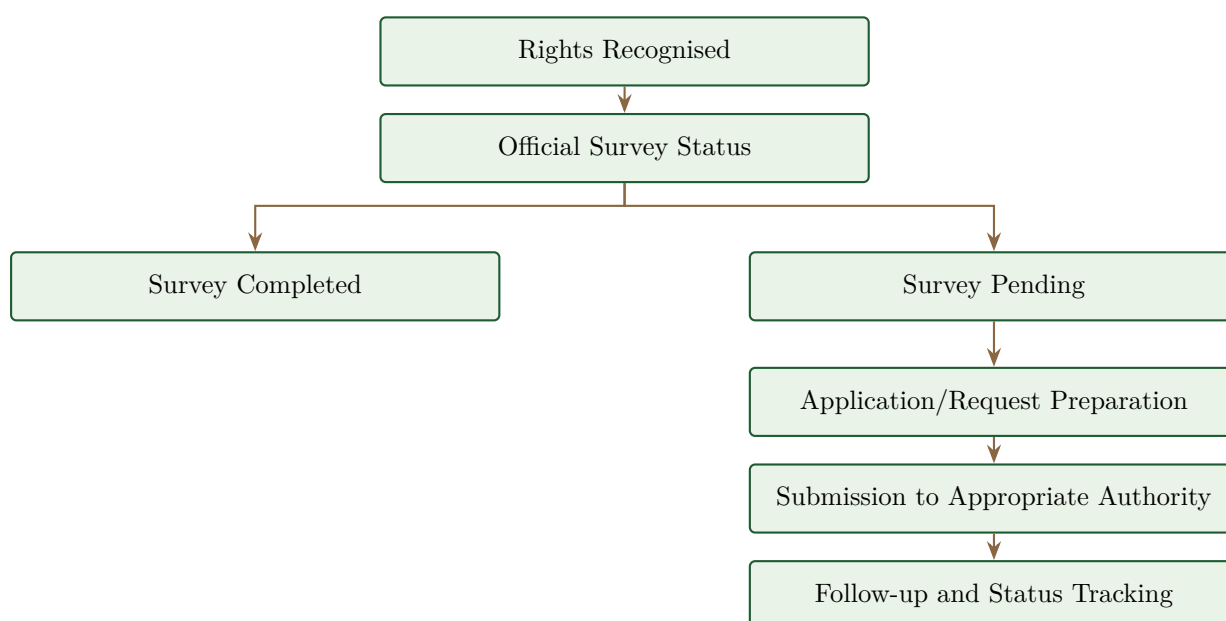
4 Recognition of CFR Areas and Resolution of Land Survey Issues

Field-level experience shows that in some cases rights may be recognised or titles granted, yet communities still face difficulties due to the absence of a proper land survey, measurement record, or clearly usable boundary information. The scheme therefore includes a **Land Survey and Boundary Coordination Component**.

4.1 Coordinating Authorities

- Forest Department
- Land Records / Survey authorities
- Maharashtra land-record institutions such as Maha Abhilekh/Bhumi Abhilekh, wherever applicable
- District-level administration
- Other competent authorities responsible for official survey and measurement

4.2 Identification and Resolution of Pending Survey Cases



Where a recognised title or right exists but the required survey or measurement has not yet been completed, the system assists in preparing a formal application or representation to the appropriate competent authority – such as the relevant district/project authority or other designated official responsible for addressing the issue.

4.3 Important Principle

VanMitra's GPS and mapping tools should be used for preliminary mapping, community participation, field documentation, identification of boundary issues, and supporting survey coordination.

Caution

These tools should **not** be presented as a replacement for an officially authorised cadastral or government land survey.

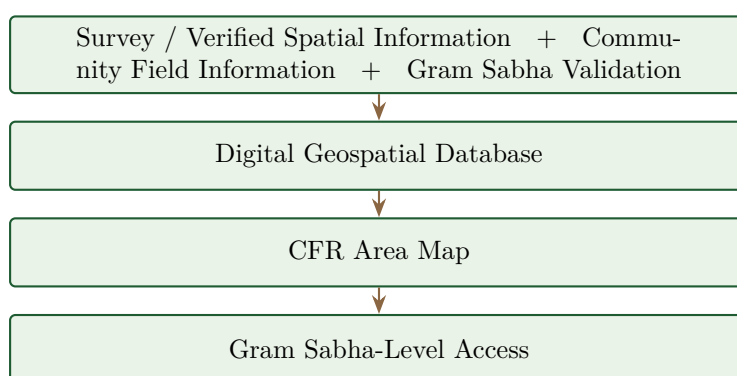
5 Development of a Geospatial CFR Land Map

Once verified survey information, official land records, or appropriately validated spatial information becomes available, VanMitra can develop a **geospatial visualisation** of the CFR area of a particular Gram Sabha.

5.1 Spatial Layers to be Integrated

- CFR boundary/area
- Village boundary
- Forest area
- Important community-use areas
- Water resources
- Paths and access routes
- Important natural resources
- Traditional-use locations, where appropriate
- Community-managed areas
- Other relevant spatial features

5.2 Mapping Workflow



This feature helps the community obtain a clearer visual understanding of the forest area associated with its recognised rights.

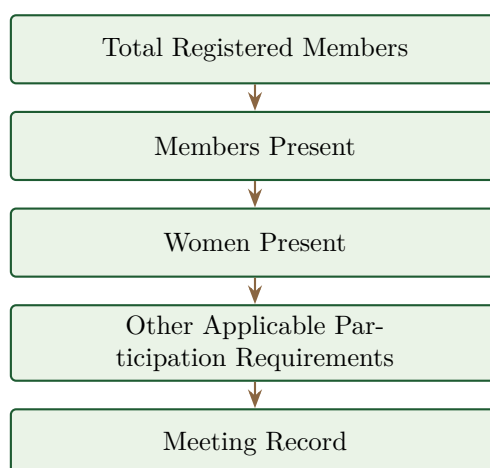
6 Digital Gram Sabha Meeting and Resolution Management

The Gram Sabha is a central community institution in the implementation and governance process. VanMitra therefore includes a dedicated **Gram Sabha Meeting and Resolution Management Module**.

6.1 Meeting Records

- Date and location of the meeting
- Agenda
- Attendance
- Participation of members
- Participation of women
- Number of eligible members present
- Discussion points
- Decisions taken
- Resolutions passed
- Supporting documents
- Digitally stored meeting records

6.2 Attendance and Participation Workflow



6.3 Digital Resolution System

After the meeting, the resolution is documented digitally and made accessible to authorised members of the Gram Sabha. The system maintains:

- Resolution number
- Meeting date
- Resolution content
- Related claim/CFR issue
- Supporting documents
- Approval/verification information
- Historical record of resolutions

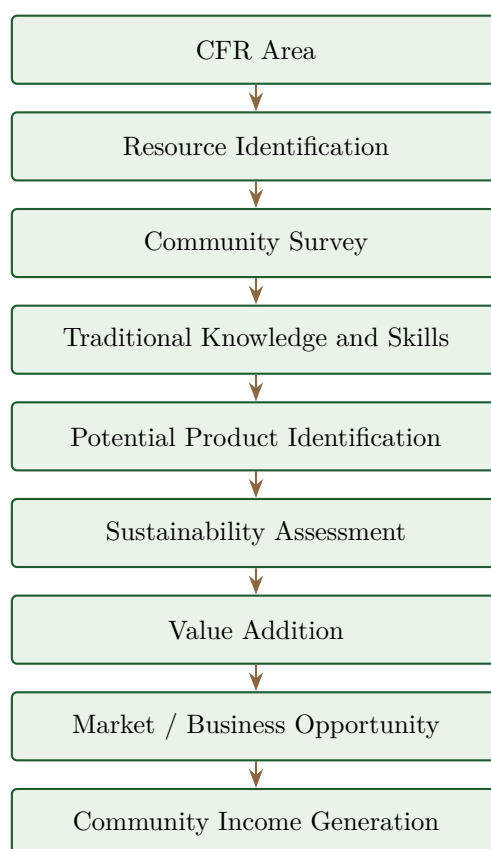
Purpose

To improve transparency, accessibility and continuity of Gram Sabha records. The digital system supports the official record-keeping process and does not independently replace legally required physical procedures or statutory authority unless formally permitted.

7 CFR Management and Community Livelihood Development

Recognition of Community Forest Rights should not be considered the final stage of the initiative. After CFR implementation, the community and institutions such as the CFRMC, Gram Sabha, NGOs, researchers and other authorised partners work together to identify sustainable opportunities for community development and livelihoods, through a **CFR Resource and Livelihood Assessment Component**.

7.1 Livelihood Development Workflow



7.2 Examples of Activities

- Identifying which forest products are available
- Identifying which products are traditionally collected
- Identifying which products have market potential
- Identifying which local skills can be developed into enterprises
- Assessing whether processing or value addition is possible
- Assessing whether a village can develop a unique community-based product or livelihood model

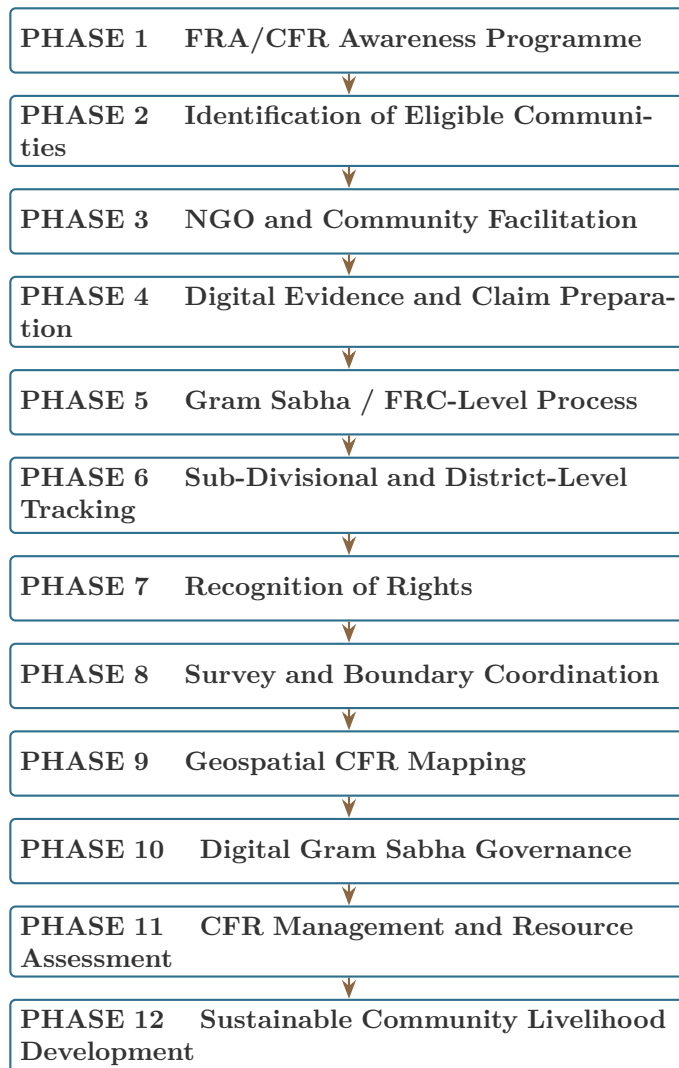
7.3 Village Resource and Livelihood Profile (Maintained on VanMitra)

- Available resources
- Seasonal availability
- Community skills
- Potential products
- Existing buyers/market connections
- Value-addition opportunities
- Sustainable utilisation plans

Objective

To support the transition from **Recognition of Rights** → **Community Management** → **Sustainable Livelihood Opportunities**.

8 Proposed Overall Implementation Model



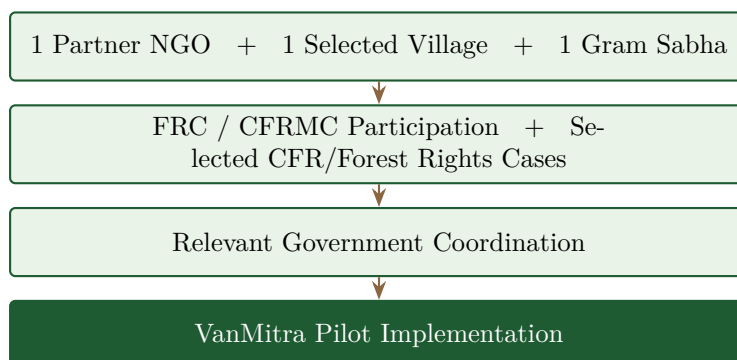
9 Role of Different Stakeholders

Stakeholder	Role
Tribal and Forest-Dwelling Community	Participate in awareness programmes; provide relevant information and evidence; participate in mapping activities and Gram Sabha decisions; contribute traditional and local knowledge; participate in CFR management and livelihood activities.
Gram Sabha	Community-level decision-making; discussion and approval of relevant matters; resolution management; community participation; governance of recognised community rights.
FRC / CFRMC	Assist in relevant community-level processes; support documentation and verification activities; coordinate with the Gram Sabha; support mapping and resource management; participate in CFR implementation and management.
NGOs	Community mobilisation; FRA/CFR awareness; field-level facilitation; documentation support; capacity building; pilot implementation; feedback on the usability of VanMitra.
Government and Relevant Authorities	Coordination for statutory processing, verification, official survey and measurement, land records, recognition of rights, and resolution of administrative issues.
VanMitra Technology Platform	Claim and document assistance; digital case management; step-by-step status tracking; GIS and spatial visualisation; survey-pending identification; Gram Sabha meeting management; resolution records; CFR monitoring support; village resource/livelihood profiling.

10 Proposed Pilot Implementation

The initiative should initially be implemented as a **small-scale pilot** rather than attempting statewide implementation.

10.1 Suggested Pilot Structure



10.2 Pilot Stages

Stage	Focus
Stage 1 – Baseline Survey	Number of households; existing FRA claims; CFR status; existing land records; survey status; Gram Sabha practices; community livelihood resources.
Stage 2 – Awareness	Conduct FRA/CFR awareness programmes.
Stage 3 – Digital Onboarding	Create village profile, community records, claim records, document records, and relevant spatial information.
Stage 4 – Claim and Governance Support	Implement claim preparation assistance, procedure tracking, mapping support, and Gram Sabha resolution management.
Stage 5 – Survey and Mapping	Coordinate identification of recognised areas, pending survey cases, boundary issues, and available official spatial records.
Stage 6 – CFR Management	Work with the community to identify forest resources, livelihood opportunities, and sustainable community enterprises.

Final Proposed Vision

The proposed scheme is designed as a **community-centred implementation and support model** for FRA and CFR, where technology is integrated with NGOs, Gram Sabha institutions and appropriate government coordination.

Awareness → Rights → Recognition → Map-
ping → Governance → Sustainable Livelihood

VanMitra will therefore not function merely as a claim-filing application. It will act as a **digital support ecosystem** that helps tribal and forest-dwelling communities throughout the broader journey of understanding, claiming, documenting, mapping, governing and sustainably managing their recognised forest rights.

The ultimate objective of the proposed implementation is to ensure that the recognition of forest rights leads not only to a formal title or administrative decision, but also to **better community awareness, transparent governance, clear spatial understanding of recognised areas, and sustainable socio-economic development of tribal and forest-dependent communities.**